Striped Bass Are in Trouble, and East Coast Anglers Are Worried

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For Bill Jakob, striped bass fishing has been a passion for more than 60 years. He remembers nights off Montauk, New York, casting into crashing waves and catching eight or nine fish, some up to 40 pounds. Many East Coast **anglers** share his worry: the fish are not showing up like they used to, and young stripers are harder to find.

Scientists say that worry is well founded. Regulators said last week that the fish have had eight years of poor **reproduction** in the Chesapeake Bay, their key habitat, and the population has declined along the Atlantic coast. Heavy fishing is only part of the story. Warming waters, poor river flow, drought, pollution, and possibly more seals and sharks may also make recovery harder.

Striped bass hatch in fresh or **brackish** water and spend their early years in **estuaries**, where rivers meet the sea. Up to 90 percent spawn and grow in the Chesapeake Bay, and they do best in cool, wet springs. When flows are low or temperatures climb too high, fewer young fish join the population, a pattern going back to 2019.

Stripers are prized because they fight hard and can be caught from shore, from Maine to Florida. Industry members say guides, trips, gear, and hotel rooms add up to about $8 billion in economic impact and as many as 100,000 jobs in the United States. Losing a top **predator** that helps balance smaller fish would put that at risk.

Regulators have changed how the fish are measured against size rules, but they have not reduced recreational catch levels. Some fishermen say stricter action, possibly even a temporary pause like one used in the 1980s, may be needed so future generations can catch striped bass. Experts and **anglers** agree the fish are not replacing themselves fast enough.

Word Treasure

anglers -- Anglers are people who fish with a rod and line.
reproduction -- Reproduction is how living things make new young of their own kind.
brackish -- Brackish water is a mix of fresh water and salty sea water.
estuaries -- Estuaries are places where rivers meet the sea.
predator -- A predator is an animal that hunts and eats other animals.

Background you need

Striped bass are a popular fish that live along the Atlantic coast and are prized by anglers because they fight hard and can be caught from shore.

They hatch in fresh or brackish water and spend their early years in estuaries, where rivers meet the sea, with the Chesapeake Bay as their key habitat.

They do best in cool, wet springs, but when river flows are low or temperatures climb too high, fewer young fish survive to join the population.

As a top predator, striped bass help balance smaller fish in the coastal ecosystem, which is one reason their decline worries both anglers and scientists.

Break it down

LEAD: East Coast anglers are worried because striped bass are not showing up like they used to, and young stripers are harder to find.

KEY EVENT: Regulators said last week that the fish have had eight years of poor reproduction in the Chesapeake Bay and the population has declined along the Atlantic coast.

+- WHO: Bill Jakob, East Coast anglers, scientists, and regulators

+- WHERE: Montauk, New York; the Chesapeake Bay; and the Atlantic coast from Maine to Florida

+- WHEN: A pattern going back to 2019, with the regulators' statement last week

EVIDENCE: Up to 90 percent spawn and grow in the Chesapeake Bay and do best in cool, wet springs, while warming waters, poor river flow, drought, pollution, and possibly more seals and sharks may make recovery harder.

IMPACT: Stripers are prized because they fight hard and can be caught from shore, and industry members say guides, trips, gear, and hotel rooms add up to about $8 billion in economic impact and as many as 100,000 jobs.

OPEN QUESTION: Regulators have changed how the fish are measured against size rules but have not reduced recreational catch levels, so some fishermen ask whether stricter action, possibly even a temporary pause, may be needed so future generations can catch striped bass.

Why it matters

Losing a top predator that helps balance smaller fish could harm coastal ecosystems and put about $8 billion in economic impact and as many as 100,000 jobs at risk.

Test what you remember

1. **How long has Bill Jakob been passionate about striped bass fishing?**
   - (A) For eight years
   - (B) About 10 years
   - (C) More than 60 years
   - (D) Since last week
2. **According to regulators, how many years of poor reproduction have striped bass had in the Chesapeake Bay?**
   - (A) Forty years
   - (B) Eight years
   - (C) Five years
   - (D) Two years
3. **Up to what share of striped bass spawn and grow in the Chesapeake Bay?**
   - (A) Up to 90 percent
   - (B) About half
   - (C) Nearly all of them from Maine to Florida
   - (D) Less than a quarter
4. **In what kind of springs do striped bass do best?**
   - (A) Springs with low river flow
   - (B) Hot, dry springs
   - (C) Springs with many seals and sharks
   - (D) Cool, wet springs
5. **What economic impact do industry members attribute to striped bass fishing in the United States?**
   - (A) About $8 million
   - (B) About $8 billion and as many as 100,000 jobs
   - (C) 100,000 hotel rooms
   - (D) $40 billion from shore fishing alone
6. **What stricter action do some fishermen say may be needed?**
   - (A) Measuring fish only in the Chesapeake Bay
   - (B) A permanent ban on all fishing
   - (C) A temporary pause like one used in the 1980s
   - (D) Moving all striped bass to Maine

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: A 4: D 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. East Coast anglers, including Bill Jakob: Worried that the fish are not showing up like they used to and that young stripers are harder to find.

2. Scientists: Say that worry is well founded.

3. Industry members: Say guides, trips, gear, and hotel rooms add up to about $8 billion in economic impact and as many as 100,000 jobs in the United States.

4. Some fishermen: Say stricter action, possibly even a temporary pause like one used in the 1980s, may be needed so future generations can catch striped bass.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):